

Prototype Trump

Happy New Year to all of you, and thank you for sticking with Digit for another full calendar year. You better stay with us for 2017 too, because it's going to be a wild ride in technology, and you're going to need your favourite navigator to help you find your way through it.

This month's cover story is about concepts, prototypes and new technologies that will take off in 2017. Concepts are raw ideas that may or may not work. They often look good, but they may not be practical. Think of every concept car image you have seen. Awesome looking things aren't they? Not practical at all, but then again since when has practical ever been fun? Then you come to prototypes. They're often ugly looking things, and look nothing at all like the concept designs and images that inspired them, and most often they barely work, or just do enough to be a proof of concept. This is all we expect of them, because it's only with painstaking research and development that final products get made, and yes, even final products rarely ever look like the concept devices that were pictured in the original artist's mind. Then again, artists aren't engineers, and nor should they be.

Those of you who have read Digit for a long time will know we aren't political, and avoid politics (and politicians) like the plague. Tech has no politics, religion and gender, and that's why we love it so much. So why on earth is the headline of this column mentioning Trump (with a capital T)?

We don't care about his politics, and we don't care about pretty much anything he does or says, except that which affects us as Indians, or as technology users. Whether we like it or not, the US has a tremendous hold on the technology world, and as a result, so does the supreme leader of that country.

As a concept Trump is far from beautiful – no artist, no matter how skilled could ever be able to pull that off. However, as a concept he was funny, and the resident troll in us all secretly wished he'd win the election, just to see what happens. Then, when he did win, he was no longer a concept, he was now a prototype. Things suddenly got serious. And that's the stage we're at right now.

Personally, I think his anti-China ranting is actually good for India. It's not at all

surprising that Apple wants to start making products in India as well now. I expect a lot more business to come our way if we play our cards right, because no big company in the US wants their business to be held to ransom by diplomatic ties between the US and China. Given their new president's whimsical nature, and the matching ego of the Chinese, trouble may very well be brewing for many tech companies.

Net neutrality fans might not like the ideas he and his cabinet have though, because the word is that the new government plans to do away with the new amendment to uphold net neutrality that was introduced just recently under Obama's watch. The republicans have long since been opposed to government interference, and believe in the free market – which means let the provider do whatever it wants to, as long as you have an option to switch providers, everything will work out. Problem is, most areas in the US don't have too many options for ISPs where they live, and providers are probably going to come together anyway, given the prospect of making more money, not just off consumers, but also off internet companies. Though this doesn't affect India, we know that as the home of most of the internet, whatever happens in the US has a ripple effect all over the world.

Another aspect of his campaign has been his promise to bring back jobs to the US, which makes me wonder how much we might lose in outsourcing revenue, even if we make some extra by manufacturing Apple devices.

In the end, only time will tell how prototype Trump will impact us as President Trump, so we have to wait and watch. Either way, there certainly are interesting times ahead for technology in 2017. What do you think will be the biggest changes (if any) for India (positive or negative) because of the new US president? Write in and tell me, I'd love to hear some varied (and perhaps better informed) views on the topic. 



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